



The Routledge International Handbook of New Critical Race and Whiteness Studies

Edited by Rikke Andreassen, Catrin Lundström,
Suvi Keskinen and Shirley Anne Tate



THE ROUTLEDGE INTERNATIONAL HANDBOOK OF NEW CRITICAL RACE AND WHITENESS STUDIES

Since its foundation as an academic field in the 1990s, critical race theory has developed enormously and has, among others, been supplemented by and (dis)integrated with critical whiteness studies. At the same time, the field has moved beyond its origins in Anglo-Saxon environments, to be taken up and re-developed in various parts of the world – leading to not only new empirical material but also new theoretical perspectives and analytical approaches. Gathering these new and global perspectives, this book presents a much-needed collection of the various forms, sophisticated theoretical developments and nuanced analyses that the field of critical race and whiteness theories and studies offers today. Organized around the themes of emotions, technologies, consumption, institutions, crisis, identities and on the margin, this presentation of critical race and whiteness theories and studies in its true interdisciplinary and international form provides the latest empirical and theoretical research, as well as new analytical approaches. Illustrating the strength of the field and embodying its future research directions, *The Routledge International Handbook of New Critical Race and Whiteness Studies* will appeal to scholars across the social sciences and humanities with interests in race and whiteness.

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1

INTRODUCTION

Writing a Handbook on critical race and whiteness theory in the time of Black Lives Matter and anti-racism backlash

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Black Lives Matters (BLMs) and the renewed interest in critical race and whiteness theory

In the Western hemisphere, May 2020 seems to have been a turning point for studies of anti-Blackness, critical race theory (CRT), whiteness and the ways in which we occupy the uneasy politics of anti-racism and white supremacy. At the specific moment that George Floyd breathed his last breath under police officer Derick Chauvin's knee, while other police officers passively watched, the world saw Black extrajudicial killing in the United States replayed on a loop. George Floyd's death was not the first murder of a Black man at police hands; neither will it be the last. Nor is Black death limited to the United States or to Black men. But it served to remind us, drawing on legal scholar Paul Butler's (2017) concept of 'the chokehold', that Black masculinity, in all its complexity – and Blackness as a whole – is under threat within an anti-Black world (Sexton 2018). The chokehold, in the United States and elsewhere, means that Black women, children and men, as well as non-binary and trans people, must now demonstrate that they are not a threat to the public and the police, while facing the perpetual national, individual and communal threat of being placed under suspicion.

When we began work on this Handbook, and when most authors began writing their chapters (in 2018 and 2019), the field of critical race and whiteness theory had not yet received much public attention. It was a theoretically advanced area that had contributed significantly to the study of discrimination, power and privileges, yet discussions in the field – of which there were many – were largely confined to the academic space. One initial aim of the Handbook was to focus on the important research that has come out of – and continues to come out of – the interdisciplinary area of critical race and whiteness studies. However, in the wake of BLM, there has been increased interest in the literature and theory that might help us comprehend our contemporary time and situation, highlighting a number of works: scholarly works by theorists such as Franz Fanon, bell hooks, Patricia Hills Collins and W.E.B. Du Bois, as well as works by authors such as Audre Lorde, Ta-Nehisi Coates, Toni Morrison and James Baldwin. In particular, the new and widespread interest in critical race studies has re-emphasised the importance of older contributions (e.g. Fanon and Du Bois), also for contemporary society.

Alongside the BLM movement (which has spread transnationally), other anti-racist movements have also arisen over the past decade. The Rhodes Must Fall movements in South Africa and the United Kingdom have demanded a decolonisation of knowledge production, institutional responsibility for colonial and imperial legacies, and a break with neoliberal economic policies (Bhambra, Gebrial and Nisancioglu 2018). Concomitantly, the campaigns ‘Why is My Curriculum White’ and ‘Why isn’t My Professor Black’ in the United Kingdom and Germany have brought attention to the racial disparities in higher education and the need to decolonise the disciplinary curricula. Anti-racist feminism, queer of colour mobilisation and the organising of minority women have been important forces in many European countries, including France, the United Kingdom, Germany and the Nordic countries (Bacchetta, El-Tayeb and Haritaworn 2015; Bassel and Emejulu 2016; Keskinen 2021; Tuzcu 2016). Urban movements in racialised and marginalised neighbourhoods have brought questions of race and class onto the political agenda (Schierup, Ålund and Kings 2014), and Muslim activists have demanded actions against anti-terror policies and anti-Muslim racism (Massoumi 2015). This broad range of anti-racist organising may not be as visible in the mainstream media as the recent BLM mobilisations. Still, the long-term grassroots politics that support these movements are posing challenges to white hegemony and demanding institutional, cultural, economic and epistemological changes that could lead to racial justice.

Backlashes and attacks on critical race theory

Simultaneously with the growing interest in racial issues – displayed by journalists, intellectuals, students and activists – a different interest in and political criticism of the field and scholarship of critical race and whiteness studies has emerged. On the one hand, the outrage, grief, trauma and public anti-racist statements of the global BLM movement that erupted in the wake of Floyd’s murder² were expressed via public protest, athletes’ taking the knee, the tearing down of statues and reflection over institutional histories of enslavement and the need for reparations. On the other hand, politicians, media figures and intellectuals responded with clapbacks against anti-racist activism. In the face of the outpouring of grief (turned to grievance) over the continued ‘state lynching’ of Black people in the United States, Latin America, Europe and Australia, nation-state backlashes appeared. In the United States, Donald Trump led the political right against what he called ‘Anti-Fa’ (anti-fascists) and Black radicals, and laid the blame for the national foment on critical race studies and intersectionality, as taught in universities. As a response, critical race theorist Kimberlé Crenshaw (renowned for coining the term ‘intersectionality’) and the African American Policy Forum sent out an email on 13 May 2021 with the subject line, ‘We need your help: CRT under attack’:

Dear Friends:

Across the United States, dangerous attacks on racial justice are spreading like wildfire. These attacks seek to prohibit the teaching and use of vital frameworks like Critical Race Theory and intersectionality and aim to smother honest engagement with our nation’s history. On Tuesday over objections from business and education groups, the Texas House voted to pass a bill ‘that supporters describe as an effort to keep “critical race theory” from being taught in schools’. Within the last week the Governor of Oklahoma signed into law Bill 1775, which restricts the teaching of racism and sexism in Oklahoma state universities and public school system.

(Crenshaw et al. 2021)

In the United States, several states have introduced bills that prohibit or restrict the teaching of CRT and limit the ways in which teachers can teach and talk about racism, sexism and other topics related to oppression. In the United Kingdom, CRT and intersectionality were first discussed in Parliament in October 2020 as problems for the state education system by Kemi Badenoch, who is herself Black, and at the time serving as Equality Minister for the Conservative Party. Boris Johnson's Conservative government took up Trump's mantle, lambasting BLM as a movement of so-called 'woke radicals', making the case that statues of slaveholders and property built from the profits accrued from slavery should remain untouched, unexcused and undebated; that reparations are not necessary for slavery, which should be forgotten; that the country's colonial past should remain intact; and that the teaching of critical race studies in school should be illegal (Trilling 2020). In Denmark, the Parliament tabled a resolution in May 2020 demanding university leadership ensure that 'the self-regulation of scientific practices is functioning' (Folketingssamling 2020) to prevent 'politics [from] being dressed up as science'. The resolution was passed under the title, 'Excessive activism in certain research environments', and the Parliamentary debate condemned specific research areas, such as critical race studies, whiteness studies, migration studies, post-colonial studies and gender studies.

In France, clapback came in the form of racially politicised debates on the place of post-colonial theory in universities and society, more widely. A French debate on 'Islamism-leftism' emerged with the Minister of Higher Education warning about 'radical' academics who are (perceivably) seeking to divide the French nation through theories of race, gender and class structures (Fassin 2021). The Minister further declared that she would initiate an investigation into the ways in which universities are dealing with such research. Other politicians, academic communities and President Emmanuel Macron have framed critical research on race, colonialism, gender and intersectionality as a threat to the French republic, seeking to control the increasing and broad social criticism around racial inequalities and a lack of engagement with colonial legacies.

These are examples of Western states' backlash against critical research, which points towards and documents inequalities in liberal democracies. They are also expressions of backlash against BLM and Black-originated thought, which are vilified as unwarranted Black insurgencies against a denied white supremacy. Moreover, such conservative movements seek to counteract the broad mobilisations and intellectual commitment to decolonise knowledge and interrogate racist practices and structures in Western societies. Critical race and whiteness scholarship is a vital intellectual resource for anti-racist and decolonial social mobilisations, and this has made it the target of political and academic forces seeking to restore the challenged social order and power structures.

Today (i.e. 2023), the field of critical race and whiteness studies has moved to the centre of political attention, where it holds an ambivalent charge: on the one hand, it is a 'tool' that can contribute to activism with a vocabulary that is capable of describing lived experiences; on the other hand, it simultaneously provides 'ammunition' for conservative and populist politicians who feel that anti-racist struggles have 'gone too far'. As editors, we have experienced how our work, within a very short period of time, has become an intellectual inspiration for both social movements and students seeking more knowledge about racism, anti-racism and (de)coloniality. At the same time, we have witnessed how the field is being used in political agendas to attack research freedom. This development was difficult to foresee. However, it highlights the need for further critical research and underscores the importance of this Handbook.

History: from racial taxonomies to critical studies of race and whiteness

Ideas of racial hierarchies and dominance have circulated in the west since the Enlightenment, when European intellectuals and scientists³ began to formulate theories, hypotheses, models and taxonomies about race and whiteness (Painter 2010). The birth of race thinking coincided with the advent of the transatlantic trade in enslaved persons, the plantation economy (based on enslavement in the Caribbean and the Americas) and European colonialism across the globe. François Bernier was the first to present an idea of racial differentiation, in the 1680s. Yet it was the Swedish botanist, zoologist and physician Carl von Linnaeus's racial taxonomy that had the most significant impact on the idea of racial difference, and it continues to demonstrate this impact, even today. Linnaeus's legacy has been targeted in contemporary BLM discussions about monuments, branding and statues. In his book *Systema naturae* ('Nature's system' or 'The order of nature'), which was first published in 1735, Linnaeus classified animals and plants, as well as humans. In doing so, he introduced the categorisation (division) of humans into distinct races and racial taxonomy, using the concept of varieties. Other researchers, such as Johann Friedrich Blumenbach (who is often presented as the founder of anthropology and infamous for introducing so-called craniometry or cranial measurement), continued to develop Linnaeus's racial division and taxonomy in the 1770s. Both of these researchers' racial taxonomies effected a refined division of the imagined races.

Following the creation of these taxonomies, a longstanding debate among anthropologists and other scientists emerged about the number of races of humans and how such races should be divided. In particular, the category of 'white' – and questions about which people belonged to it – stirred discussion well into the twentieth century. The category of white has, at various times and locations, been attributed to the Greeks, Vikings, Georgians, Germans, Caucasians, Circassians, Indo-Europeans, Aryans and Nordics. Over the centuries, it has also been defined in contrast to – and sometimes replaced by – other groups, such as Native Americans, Jews, Muslims, Sámi, Irish, Italians and, to some extent, other southern Europeans (Garner 2007). For example, the Irish were once categorised as Celts – considered a subordinate group to Anglo-Saxons or Germans within the British Empire – but they were eventually categorised among other white Europeans, in the context of their emigration to the United States and increasing racial segregation in the enlargement of whiteness (see also Andreassen 2015; Grosfoguel 2003; Ignatiev 1995; Painter 2010).

The legitimisation of colonial power, displacement and slavery went hand in hand with ideas of whiteness, as linked to qualities such as strength, purity, morality, civilisation and beauty. In 1790, for example, the German philosopher and historian Christoph Meiners described the Germans as 'the tallest and most beautiful men' on earth with 'the whitest, most blooming and most delicate skin' and 'a purity of blood' (Painter 2010, pp. 89–90). At the time, European whiteness contained different shades, depending on a combination of, among other things, language, climate and history. Towards the end of the nineteenth century, the American economist William Z. Ripley worked out a model of European sub-races, on the basis of facial features, hair colour, eye colour, nose shape and body length, as well as other factors. Ripley particularly emphasised the shape of the skull, following Swedish anthropologist Anders Retzius's 'index of skulls', which he linked to intelligence and beauty.

Ideas about European whiteness were thus partly developed in the United States. In the early nineteenth century, Thomas Carlyle spoke of Germans as 'the only genuine European people, unmixed with strangers' (Painter 2010, p. 160). Furthermore, Swedes and other Scandinavians were portrayed as superior representatives of hyper-whiteness and Nordic beauty – an idea that survived in the United States well into the twentieth century (Lunde

2010). For example, in Carl C. Brigham's estimate of the proportion of bloodstock in 1923, Swedes were classified as the whitest of all whites, attributed with 100 per cent Nordic white blood; Norwegians and Danes followed in second and third places, respectively. Even within the Nordic region, anthropologists and race biologists sought to identify the characteristics of the 'superior' Nordic race (Hübinette 2017), drawing distinctions to other groups in the Nordic region – notably the Indigenous Sámi people, the Finns and the Roma. These were categorised as inferior racial groups on a lower cultural level, and subjected to skull measuring and other physical scrutinisation (Broberg and Roll-Hansen 2003; Keskinen 2019).

In nineteenth-century Europe, the concept of race became increasingly attached to nationalist imaginaries of homogeneous people, resulting in assimilatory, repressive and genocidal measures towards minorities and Indigenous people, including the Jews, the Sámi and the Roma (Keskinen, Skaptadóttir and Toivanen 2019a; Lentin 2004; van Baar 2011). Religious-based anti-Semitic beliefs came to merge with a new type of anti-Semitism based on race thinking, while Roma and Sámi people were ascribed to separate racial groups through the transformation of cultural stereotypes into racial characteristics. The Holocaust was detrimental to both the Jews and the Roma, while the Indigenous Sámi people largely suffered from cultural genocide, resulting in serious damage to their languages and culture (Kuokkanen 2020).

Due to the expanded boundaries of American whiteness, during the twentieth century, various European immigrants in the United States became included in a common category of white. From the 1950s onwards, these ethnic groups, which had previously been perceived as 'not quite white' – among them Italians, Irish, Finns, Poles and other Slavic immigrant groups, and even Jews – were placed into a common white American majority population, based on a form of 'white identity politics' and a 'possessive investment in whiteness', supported by 'both public policy and private prejudice' (Guglielmo 2003; Lipsitz 2006, p. vii; Wray 2006). This homogenisation of a variety of European immigrant groups took place not least through economic policy, housing policy and the segregation of white American suburbs, which were predominantly populated by previously ethnic Europeans (Lipsitz 2006; Zuberi and Bonilla-Silva 2008). As it assumed increasingly sharp racial segregation, the residential sector became highly influential in determining both racial and class affiliation (Hartigan 1999; Pred 2000).

As this shows, the boundaries of whiteness have historically been intimately intertwined with the economic conditions of different groups – and thus social class (see also Andreassen 2015). Drawing on this intersection, North American researchers have noticed how other groups, such as fair-skinned Latin Americans and certain East Asian groups, have been included in American whiteness, in line with the continuously unstable and 'ever-expanding boundaries of whiteness' and 'the Latin Americanisation' of racial stratification in the United States (Bonilla-Silva 2002; Warren and Twine 1997). But whereas the expanding boundaries of whiteness may include some light-skinned Latinos, Asian Americans, Middle Eastern Americans and multi-racials as 'honorary whites', such dialectics continue to exclude those defined as 'collective Blacks' (Bonilla-Silva 2002).

In Europe, questions about race, racism and whiteness have been addressed in connection with the horrors of the Holocaust (Goldberg 2009) and, increasingly, in the (post-)colonial context that makes European colonialism and its legacies central for understanding contemporary societies. Post-World War II migration from former colonies to many European countries – notably the United Kingdom, France, Belgium, Sweden and the Netherlands – gradually changed both the demographics and the social relations in those countries, in ways that make it difficult to ignore the intertwining of race, ethnicity and social class. Even European countries with few or no colonies were confronted with questions of race, racism

and white supremacy following the increasing migration from post-colonial countries in Africa, Latin America, the Caribbean and Asia. This made visible colonial representations and entanglements with the neo-colonial economic order, which these countries shared with their European neighbours (Keskinen et al. 2009; Loftsdóttir and Jensen 2012; Lüthi, Falk and Purtschert 2015).

The birth of critical race and whiteness studies

As the history of race and whiteness testifies, racial categories are historical constructions that developed within particular societal contexts. CRT in the United States (Delgado and Stefancic 2017), as well as the more global research field of race critical theories (Essed and Goldberg 2002), described new ways of understanding race as a socially constructed category, through the work of, for example: Kimberlé Crenshaw, Joe Feagin, Linda Martín Alcoff, Anne Anlin Cheng, bell hooks, David Theo Goldberg, Philomena Essed, Stuart Hall, Paul Gilroy, Gloria Wekker, Patricia Hill Collins, Eduardo Bonilla-Silva, Michael O. Hardimon and Charles W. Mills, to name only a few. Rather than abandoning the highly problematic concept of race, these scholars developed new ways of studying and analysing race, with regard to racial segregation, colonialism and ongoing racial inequalities, developing concepts such as ‘racial formation’, ‘intersectionality’, ‘white racial frame’, the ‘racial contract’, ‘racial grammar’, ‘everyday racism’ and the ‘white gaze’ (Ahmed 2007; Alcoff 2005; Bonilla-Silva 2003; Cheng 2001; Crenshaw 1989; Essed 1991; Goldberg 2009; Mills 1997; Omi and Winant 1986; Yancy 2004).

In parallel, during the 1980s and 1990s, the interdisciplinary research field of critical whiteness studies gradually emerged in the English-speaking world, through the writings of Marilyn Frye (1983), Audre Lorde (1984), Peggy McIntosh (1988), David R. Roediger (1991), Ruth Frankenberg (1993), Richard Dyer (1997), Ghassan Hage (1998), Alastair Bonnett (2004) and many others. This field promoted a new and conscious way of studying whiteness, from a perspective that was not based on supposed neutrality and normality (hence the prefix ‘critical’). The field grew alongside CRT and race critical research, notably in North American academia, focused mainly on Black and other non-white minorities, especially Latin Americans and Asians (Eng 2001; Eng and Han 2019). As the name implies, the aim was to shift focus in order to question the otherwise presumed and often invisible and normalised whiteness: ‘Whites must be seen to be white’, as Dyer (1997, p. 45) puts it.

The field of critical whiteness studies, which today encompasses thousands of books and articles, not only examines the existence of an all-encompassing white hegemonic structure and norm, but also how whiteness reproduces itself as normalcy and privilege in a variety of ways, through a wide range of practices and in different historical and localised contexts (Andreassen and Vitus 2015; Garner 2007, 2014; Keskinen and Andreassen 2017; Leonard 2016; Loftsdóttir and Jensen 2012; Lundström 2014; Moreton-Robinson, Casey and Nicoll 2008; Shome 2014; Wekker 2016). Whiteness can thus be described as an idea of normalcy, combined with a hegemonic racialised structure, position or identity that is reproduced through a set of practices and boundaries that ‘render white privilege invisible’, yet are maintained socially, historically, culturally and politically over time and across national boundaries (Frankenberg 1993; McIntosh 1988; Twine and Gallagher 2008, p. 6). Richard Dyer identifies whiteness as a process of racialisation based on a privileged position and perspective that defines people and practices racialised as white as normal and allows them to pass as invisible, ensuring ‘whiteness consists in invisible properties, and whiteness as power is maintained by being unseen’ (Dyer 1997, p. 45).

Black feminism, gender and intersectionality

The notion of whiteness as an ‘invisible’ norm that perpetually defines difference explains why the histories of race and whiteness – and critical studies of these subjects – are intertwined. It further emphasises the importance of examining this normative structure from the perspectives of those who have experienced exclusion from it, by ‘not’ being white. To not be white ‘is to inhabit the negative: it is to be “not”. The pressure of this “not” is another way of describing the social and existential realities of racism’ (Ahmed 2007, p. 161; see also Lorde 1984). Whiteness is particularly visible to those who are not included in it – that is, to people racialised as non-white. Or, as Audre Lorde (1984) phrases it, the production of whiteness works by assigning race and ethnicity to others, with those ‘others’ becoming aware of both whiteness and their own ‘otherness’. Focusing on the interconnection between race and whiteness means not taking the invisible claim of whiteness for granted as the normative point of view. As Sara Ahmed reminds us:

Whiteness is only invisible to those who inhabit it. To those who don’t, the power of whiteness is maintained by being seen; we see it everywhere, in the casualness of white bodies in spaces, crowded in parks, meetings, in white bodies that are displayed in films and advertisements, in white laws that talk about white experiences, in ideas of the family made up of clean white bodies. I see those bodies as white, not human.

(Ahmed 2004, p. 14)

Sara Ahmed describes whiteness studies as a field that ‘begins with the Black critique of how whiteness works as a form of racial privilege, as well as the effects of that privilege on the bodies of those who are recognised as black’ (Ahmed 2004, p. 2; cf. Lorde 1984). Fundamental texts, such as *This Bridge Called My Back* (Moraga and Anzaldúa 1981), *All the Women Are White, All the Blacks Are Men, But Some of Us Are Brave* (Hull et al. 1982), *Ain’t I a Woman: Black Women and Feminism* (hooks 1981), *Sister Outsider: Essays and Speeches* (Lorde 1984) and *Borderlands/La Frontera: The New Mestiza* (Anzaldúa 1987), have laid the foundation of both Black feminist studies and critical whiteness studies.

A number of scholars have documented the intersections between race, ethnicity, gender and sexuality. Crenshaw coined the term ‘intersectionality’ in her article ‘Demarginalizing the intersection of race and sex: A Black feminist critique of antidiscrimination doctrine, feminist theory and antiracist politics’ (1989) and further developed the term in the article ‘Mapping the margins: Intersectionality, identity politics, and violence against women of color’ (1991). Crenshaw argues that Black women’s experiences of oppression cannot simply be understood as racism experienced as a Black person or sexism experienced as a woman; rather, Black women’s experiences are multidimensional, as race and gender intersect and oppressions occur via the entanglement of gender and race. In other words, the categories of race and gender (in addition to class, sexuality, age and others) mutually influence and reinforce each other.

As a legal scholar, Crenshaw points to how the law treats all people as equal only in theory, and how the lack of an intersectional approach to discrimination and oppression make Black women vulnerable. Black women’s treatment and experiences of racism are not equivalent to those of Black men, just as their experiences of sexism are not equivalent to those of white women. Uniquely, their oppression is shaped by their intersecting identities of race and gender. Crenshaw thus advocates for the inclusion of various categories of oppression when analysing social inequalities or providing support for individuals in need. Illustratively, she

describes how actions against domestic violence (e.g. the provision of shelter) must address not only sexism and violence, but also race, social class and migration status (Crenshaw 1991).

Crenshaw's development of intersectionality builds upon Black feminism in the United States. Here, theorists and activists such as Angela Davis (1981) have noted that issues of women's rights are about not only gender and sexism, but also racism and racialisation. Davis, for instance, describes how white and Black women are united in the struggle for reproductive rights, including the right to abortion, but that they are positioned differently in the struggle, due to race. Unlike white women, Black women are subjected to forced sterilisation programmes; thus, their fight for reproductive rights also includes a fight against what we would today term 'necropolitics' (Mbembe 2019).

Another example of how both scholarship and activism require a focus on the intersections of gender, race and sexuality is the 'Combahee River Collective statement' (1977), written by a collective of Black feminists, addressing the particular oppression experienced by Black lesbian women. The statement describes how the (white) feminist movement and the (male-focused) civil rights movement at the time were not addressing the interlocked oppression faced by lesbians of colour. Another important scholar is Patricia Hill Collins, whose book *Black Feminist Thought* (1990) similarly underscores the intersections between race and gender, while also pointing to the rich archive of Black literature, music and poetry that express and embody Black feminist thought.

bell hooks – a central figure within Black feminism – likewise advocates for the inclusion of race in analyses of feminism and sexism. She points to how bodily differences, such as skin colour and hair texture, represent historical oppressions and inequalities that continue to influence contemporary lives. In the United States, the history of enslavement and ideas of Black women as hypersexual and promiscuous (which contributed to upholding slavery and perpetuating atrocities against Black women) influence sexism against Black women in contemporary society (hooks 1992). hooks also describes how historical constructions of Black masculinity as dangerous and violent influence contemporary discrimination against Black men in the United States (e.g. in relation to police violence and surveillance; cf. BLM). The police brutality exemplified by the killing of George Floyd has deep historical roots, dating back to slavery and Jim Crow laws. On the European continent, Frantz Fanon (2008/1952) described how – as a Black man in (white) Europe – he was perceived as a potential danger (by white people), while simultaneously being framed as exotic, due to a historical understanding of the Black body as hypersexual. Fanon illustrated how the Western myth about Black men's lust for white women plays into the (white) fear of and fascination with the Black man. Another perspective on the intersections between CRT, gender and sexuality is provided by David Eng (2001), in his book *Racial Castration*. Here, he investigates the role of race in (white) perceptions of Asian American male sexuality and, vice versa, the role of sexuality in race formations of Asian American males. As the title emphasises, these race formations frame Asian American males as emasculated or homosexualised (i.e. castrated).

Sara Ahmed's extensive work on affect theory, race and whiteness reflects upon the ways in which racism and sexism are experienced and felt (2004, 2006). Drawing upon Frantz Fanon and Audre Lorde, Ahmed examines how larger structures of racism and racial privileges affect lives and everyday practices. In this way, Ahmed, Lorde and Fanon describe what we might discuss as the phenomenology or 'lived experiences' of being racialised as non-white in a society of white hegemony; that is, experiences of discrimination and 'othering' related to everyday life in ordinary places and spaces, including public transport, schools, dinner parties and so forth. Similarly, a number of scholars have examined the ways in which

race and racialisation shape everyday lives via an analysis of emotions and affects (e.g. Ahmed 2013; Andreassen and Vitus 2015; Bonilla-Silva 2012, 2019).

By the 1990s, the interdisciplinary field of critical whiteness studies was flourishing. Developed in dialogue with CRT, post-colonial feminism and Black feminist research (hooks 1981, 1984; Gilroy 1987; Sandoval 1991; Trinh 1989), it was described as ‘the daughter’ of the research conducted by (primarily) Black American scholars since the early twentieth century (Twine 2011). Illustratively, the American sociologist Ruth Frankenberg effected a crucial turn within whiteness studies by empirically investigating the social and cultural aspects of growing up white as a white woman, thus foregrounding whiteness as ‘visible’, taking inspiration from Black feminist scholars. Frankenberg defined whiteness as ‘a set of locations that are historically, socially, politically, and culturally produced, and, moreover, are intrinsically linked to unfolding relations of domination’ (Frankenberg 1993, p. 6). In her ground-breaking book *White Women, Race Matters: The Social Construction of Whiteness* (1993), Frankenberg laid out the intersectional location of white women and the ways in which white women are gendered and racialised as white. Her work was pioneering, in the sense that she empirically investigated ‘the possible ways of living whiteness’ (1993, p. 1), rather than focusing on whiteness as a hegemonic structure. Accordingly, she developed a theoretical framework for how the position of whiteness ‘is delimited by the relation of racism at that moment and in that place’ (Frankenberg 1993, p. 236).

Three waves of whiteness studies

The tradition of critically examining whiteness stretches further back than the origins of what we today term ‘whiteness studies’. France Winddance Twine and Charles Gallagher (2008) propose a periodisation of whiteness studies, locating the foundations of contemporary critical whiteness studies in earlier studies of race and racism from (predominately) Black scholars – notably the historian and sociologist W.E.B. Du Bois. Already at the beginning of the twentieth century, Du Bois wrote about white privilege and double-consciousness as a veil for Black Americans. He argued that this double-consciousness defines the position of Black and non-white in a society dominated by whites as: ‘this sense of always looking at one’s self through the eyes of others’ in a racist white society – ‘a world which yields him no true self-consciousness’ (cited in Gates and Oliver 1999, p. xxvii). Double-consciousness describes a state of being both inside and outside oneself and one’s body at the same time – something that all non-whites in the Western world, by and large, experience. Frantz Fanon’s autobiographical post-colonial classic *Black Skin, White Masks* (1952) also represents a foundational text for the field, in its treatment of the experience of being Black in a white majority society: ‘For not only must the black man be black; he must be black in relation to the white man’ (Fanon 2008/1952, p. 90).

The second wave of whiteness studies included more recent critical scholars and writers, such as James Baldwin and Ralph Ellison, ‘who continued on in the DuBoisian tradition of challenging and making white supremacy and institutional racism visible’ (Twine and Gallagher 2008, p. 10). It also consisted of the flourishing 1990s research tradition in legal studies, history and cultural studies that identified a wide array of white structures and examined representations of whiteness. Legal scholars such as Cheryl Harris (1993), who argued for whiteness as property, and Ian Haney López (1996), who examined the implications of legal definitions of white and non-white for citizenship, played a central role in this wave. Moreover, the work of the historian David R. Roediger – notably his book *The Wages of Whiteness. Race and the Making of the American Working Class* (1991) – was also influential. Roediger

drew on Du Bois's conceptualisation of 'the wages of whiteness' (1935) to study how the white working class in the United States gained from whiteness as a psychological resource, despite a lack of material means, and what it meant to be included in the category of 'free Americans'. Roediger's work was, thus, an important development of Marxist theory, in relation to critical race and whiteness studies. Finally, in his book *White: Essays on Race and Culture* (1997), the British film scholar Richard Dyer studied representations of whiteness in Western image, religion and popular culture, making an important contribution to contemporary understandings of the entanglement between whiteness and cultural production.

The third (and current) wave of whiteness studies focuses on 'cultural practices and discursive strategies', including intersectional perspectives on race and other categories, such as class, gender and sexuality (Twine and Gallagher 2008, p. 13). With this shift, whiteness studies has avoided 'the tendency towards essentializing accounts of whiteness by locating race as one of many social relations that shape individual and group identity' (Twine and Gallagher 2008, p. 6). Thus, third-wave perspectives, according to Twine and Gallagher (2008, p. 6), have the capacity to study 'whiteness as a multiplicity of identities that are historically grounded, class specific, politically manipulated and gendered social locations that inhabit local custom and national sentiments within the context of the new "global village"'. With this new way of studying whiteness, the field has come to examine 'the role whiteness and white identities play in framing and reworking racial categories, hierarchies and boundaries', thus moving 'beyond "voyeuristic ethnographic accounts" and personal narratives' (Twine and Gallagher 2008, p. 5).

Another important turn of the third wave of whiteness studies in the United States, Twine and Gallagher argue, is its shift from studying predominantly European immigrant groups to examining identity formations among groups originating in Latin America, the Caribbean and other non-European areas (in particular, the Hispanic/Latino population). Among these identity formations, some migrants and descendants identify as white, while others view themselves as persons of colour, Black or mixed race. The result of this research has been a more complex understanding of the construction and claiming of white identity. In the second and third waves of research, a broad, transdisciplinary and transnational field of critical whiteness studies has developed on several continents (e.g. Ware and Back 2002; Fine et al. 1997; Garner 2007, 2015; Hage 1998; Hill 1997; Hughey 2012; Twine 1998, 2011; Yancy 2004; Ware 2015).

Almost a decade after Twine and Gallagher's (2008) mapping of whiteness studies, Steve Garner (2017, p. 1590) argued that the third wave had 'unfurled' across the globe and, despite its many forms, shared a few starting points – notably a focus on power structures and 'the delicate balance between micro and macro, and between structure and agency'. In his view, one of the strongest strands of third-wave whiteness studies is the analysis of white nationalism and the mainstreaming of white supremacy in Europe, the United States, Brazil and many other parts of the world. Today, ideas and positions that were previously associated with far-right agendas have become increasingly understood as 'ordinary' politics and media discourses. Moreover, the third wave has produced nuanced analyses of multiple localities and national contexts, thus broadening the scope from the previous focus on the United States. Indeed, our Handbook builds on this history and seeks to expand analyses of race and whiteness to under theorised continents and countries. We envision that increased regional emphases (Goldberg 2009), which can draw out the complexities of global processes of race, racism and whiteness, will characterise what we might term the emerging fourth wave of whiteness studies. This will further shift the focus from (merely) the United States context to other parts of the world. We envision this fourth wave embodying a duality of local and regional focus and analysis on

one hand, while, on the other hand, addressing the expanding global digital platforms and the increased (global) digitalisations of our cultural and social lives. While this anticipated fourth wave in many ways is directly linked to the third wave, we do believe that it might differ from the third wave by causing more political opposition; placing critical race and whiteness studies much more in the centre of debate and radical politics. At the same time, we foresee critical studies of race and whiteness studies increasingly being employed by activists, students and intellectuals, as well as anti-racist movements, in order to understand contemporary – local and global – situations and to provide vocabularies and tools to resist injustice.

The critique of the critical in critical whiteness studies

The formation of a field of whiteness studies has been rightly contested. As Dyer expressed at the establishment of the field (1997, p. 10): ‘My blood runs cold at the thought that talking about whiteness could lead to the development of something called “White Studies” [...] amounting to a statement of “white ethnicity”, the acceptable face of white nationalism.’ Studies on whiteness, Ahmed argues, must not simply re-establish white people and white agency at the centre of the agenda, or ‘even produce the white subject as the origin of good feeling’ (Ahmed 2004, pp. 2, 33). Hence, the prefix ‘critical’ does not guarantee that the research is truly critical, ‘in the sense of challenging relations of power that remain concealed as institutional norms or givens’ (Ahmed 2004, p. 10). A number of scholars have critiqued the field of whiteness studies for turning whiteness into an ‘essential something’ (Fine et al. 1997, p. xi). In her essay ‘Whitewashing race: A critical perspective on whiteness’, Margaret L Andersen (2003, p. 21) warns that whiteness studies must not eclipse ‘the study of racial power, focusing solely on white identity, and analysing “whites” in the absence of the experience of people of color’. Similarly, in their recent *Handbook on Critical Studies in Whiteness*, Hunter and van der Westhuizen suggest that we must shift our perspective from writing *about* whiteness ‘to begin to speak, act, write, edit *through* whiteness’ (2022, emphasis in original).

In a recent article, ‘From wave to tsunami: The growth of third wave whiteness’, Gallagher and Twine (2017) respond to Steve Garner’s ‘Surfing the third wave of whiteness studies’ (2017). In Garner’s commentary, he poses the question of whether whiteness studies has remained ‘true to the first wave origin: *make white supremacy visible*’ (Garner 2017). In their response, Gallagher and Twine (2017) identify some of the challenges associated with studies of whiteness and the field of critical whiteness studies, calling scholars to address the urgent issue of increasing right-wing political support among the white working class:

How has Right wing politics (globally) managed the paradox of the diminishing returns of whiteness as a category of privilege, for the poor and working classes. A neo-conservative ideological turn has decoupled, or separated whiteness from its location as a cultural, political and economic site of privilege. In other words, whiteness is discussed as if it is a politically neutral category that exists outside of a racial structure. Racial justice and racial inequality is eluded. [...] The perception by a majority of whites that we now are colourblind is why the Black Lives Matter movement was so jarring for some whites; in a colourblind America ‘all lives’ should matter and to privilege black lives over others is, from a colourblind perspective a form of racism.

(Gallagher and Twine 2017)

While Gallagher and Twine draw attention to the ideology of colour-blindness in explaining the rise of the far right in the United States, others critically interrogate claims that the white

working class is the main force behind the increase in white nationalism. Building on a broad literature review, Gurminder Bhambra (2017) argues that it was, in fact, the white middle class that both brought Donald Trump to power in 2016 and dominated among Brexit voters in the United Kingdom Referendum (also in 2016). According to her, many studies of these recent political events have been characterised by a methodological whiteness, eliding the fact that large sections of the working class consist of persons of colour, who predominantly voted against both Trump and Brexit. Satnam Virdee and Brendan McGeever (2018) argue that the United Kingdom ‘Leave’ campaign was successful due to its ability to draw upon a nostalgic longing for the golden days of the British colonial empire and a narrative of retreat from an unfamiliar ‘globalised’ world that has replaced familiar images of the nation. The analyses by Bhambra and Virdee and McGeever underscore the need to address the intersections of race, whiteness and class when seeking to understand major political changes, as well as when attempting to avoid an uncritical centring of white experiences and identities.

The critique of colour-blindness and white innocence

One of the most important contributions of studies of race and whiteness is perhaps its rejection of the notions of colour-blindness and racial ignorance (Mueller 2020). As Eduardo Bonilla-Silva and others have shown in numerous books and articles, a colour-blind society is not anti-racist; rather, it approaches racial matters abstractly, by applying cultural explanations to minorities’ racialised experiences and positionings in society, neutralising racial phenomena in society and, last but not least, foregrounding the claim that racial discrimination has, in general, disappeared (Bonilla-Silva 2002, 2003; cf. Beaman 2015; Crenshaw et al. 2019; Gallagher 2003; Hughey 2012; Lipsitz 2006; Myong 2009).

Many countries in continental Europe (e.g. Sweden, Germany and France) embrace colour-blindness, espousing that ‘race has no “meaning”’ anymore (Beaman and Petts 2020, p. 4). Colour-blindness here is ‘a cherished ideal—something aspirational and worth actively claiming as a central part of one’s identity and politics’ (Burke 2017, p. 859). These countries are thus both anti-racial – by rejecting the use of the word ‘race’ – and ‘non-racial’ – by denying ‘the reality of race’ (Beaman and Petts 2020, p. 4): “‘We will not tolerate racism’ [...] quickly becomes “‘We cannot speak the language of race”’. This is a coded way of saying “‘We cannot speak of race”’ (Goldberg 2006, p. 362). In Sweden and Finland, for example, official statistics only record country of birth; thus, non-white minorities who are citizens by birth are not identified. This practice maintains racial ignorance and reproduces the idea that racial and ethnic categories have no implications for society (Hübinette and Lundström 2011; Hübinette and Mählck 2015; Myong 2009).

In this regard, critical studies on race and whiteness provide a language for what has been silenced in official colour-blind discourses. As Twine and Gallagher (2008, p. 5) attest, these ‘new empirical studies of whiteness and white identities pose novel questions that challenge existing historical and contemporary accounts of racial identity construction [...] exposing the often invisible or masked power relations within existing racial hierarchies’. Colour-blindness is therefore not an answer to far-right movements and white identity politics, nor to racial segregation and hegemonic whiteness. Rather, as critical race and whiteness scholars have suggested, we need to develop methods and methodologies to understand the impact of race in society and to conceptualise its persistence (Zuberi and Bonilla-Silva 2008).

Researchers have shown that racists and anti-racists, as members of the white majority population, share similar meanings of race that reproduce hegemonic whiteness, in terms of white perspectives and white privileges (Hughey 2012). Hübinette and Lundström (2014)

argue that the period of ‘white solidarity’ in Sweden – involving the construction of the Swedish nation as the most tolerant, anti-racist and progressive in the world – was not fundamentally different from the previous period of ‘white purity’, which was built on eugenics and scientific race thinking. This makes it possible to talk about a shift from one whiteness regime to another of hegemonic whiteness. Hübinette and Lundström’s argument echoes that of Gloria Wekker in her study of Dutch whiteness and the disidentification with the image of the Netherlands as an old colonial power. In her book *White Innocence: Paradoxes of Colonialism and Race* (2016), Wekker identifies a form of white innocence that she believes characterises Dutch whiteness – an innocence that strives to liberate itself from a colonial past. This interpretation could be extended to include the Swedish case and its moving away from the former period of race science and eugenics towards a national self-image as anti-racist and tolerant.

These arguments build on the idea that there are interconnections between ‘good’ (anti-racist) whiteness and ‘bad’ (racist) whiteness, despite their diametrically opposed expressions: both emanate from a similar superior position of whiteness. Shannon Sullivan (2014) argues that disidentification with and distancing from the morally ‘bad’ white racist is a core component of the construction of the good, white (middle-class) anti-racist. The distinction between these two positions is made through the production of the morally superior, good, middle-class, white person, who is distinguished from the morally inferior, working-class, white (racist) person who is perceived to support right-wing populist politics. The connection between the lower classes and the ‘bad’ (and fundamentally different) whiteness is emblematic of the expression ‘white trash’, in which (working-class) whiteness – unlike middle-class whiteness – is marked and referred to as an inferior kind of whiteness. Sullivan holds that white anti-racism operates through an ‘othering’ of evil white historical figures, including American slaveholders, British colonial masters and German Nazis. These figures are demonised as a different kind of white person, with nothing to do with ‘us’. Thereby, they are made incomprehensible or even irrelevant, and disconnected from both historical and contemporary structures to support the ideas of individual anomalies and colour-blindness and a self-perception that ‘we’ do not ‘see’ race, and therefore racism is not a relevant issue for us.

Ashley ‘Woody’ Doane (2003) critiques the colour-blind ideology, arguing that it permeates an idea that society is beyond race:

What emerges is an image of a ‘postracial’ or ‘color-blind’ society, one in which race is no longer viewed as a significant obstacle to social and economic participation and where racism is no longer a structural phenomenon but is limited to hate crimes or other acts of discrimination committed by a small number of prejudiced individuals (who may be of any race).

(Doane 2003, p. 13)

In order to move beyond white supremacy and innocence, Sullivan (2014, p. 162) argues that white middle-class people must clean up their ‘unhealthy crap’ and move away from ‘the abjection of white trash, the othering of white ancestors, the distancing strategy of color-blindness, and the dominance of white guilt, shame, and betrayal’. Instead, they must develop ‘a critical form of self-love that helps transform whiteness’. As Alfred J. López (2005) puts it, white guilt has ‘been the prevalent condition blocking postcolonial studies from any careful examination of precisely *how* whiteness has managed all the damage it has inflicted on its others and what other forms a postcolonial whiteness might take’ (p. 23, emphasis in original).

Sullivan argues that anti-racism is closely linked to gender, as white women seem particularly preoccupied with their moral position as ‘innocent’ and ‘pure’, and differentiated from the ‘dirty’ position of the white racist man. At the same time, white men are increasingly taking up the role of angry white man – in different shapes, through different actions and in different networks, as manifested in ‘incel’ movements and domestic terrorism (e.g. Anders Behring Breivik in Norway 2011) – and thereby expressing an increasingly toxic white masculinity. Such contemporary movements call for careful analysis, in consideration of social class, gender, race and marginalisation.

The crisis of white masculinity and the crisis of white hegemony

Research on ‘the crisis of white masculinity’ has largely focused on the United States, even if insights from these studies have inspired analyses of other national settings (Carroll 2011; Frey 2014; Hartigan 2005). A core theoretical concept of this research is ‘aggrieved entitlement’, as coined by the American sociologist Michael Kimmel (2013). Kimmel uses this concept to describe the condition that arises when men’s expectations regarding economic advance, social prominence and authority in both the public and private spheres are not only challenged, but increasingly unfulfilled. Today, a number of countries – perhaps most obviously Eastern and Western white and semi-white nations – have particular versions of angry white men in politics (e.g. Donald Trump, Jair Bolsonaro, Viktor Orbán and Vladimir Putin), as well as a rising number of angry white women (cf. Ware 2015). While studies have not been able to identify a decrease in the power and privileges related to white masculinity, there is a widespread assumption among certain groups of men – notably in Western societies – that they have been deprived of their rightful positions and benefits, due to a ‘feminism gone too far’ and politics aimed at enhancing gender equality and the non-discrimination of ethnic and racial minorities (Keskinen 2013; Norocel 2013; Norocel et al. 2020).

This politicisation of gender links to ideas of ‘anti-feminism’ and ‘anti-gender’ that have been articulated within discourses about the ‘crisis of multiculturalism’. Such discourses portray especially Muslim males as sexual ‘others’ who threaten national and European values; they also frame feminists and queer movements as dangers to the existing social and gender orders (Eriksson 2013; Gutiérrez Rodríguez, Tuzcu and Winkel 2018; Keskinen 2013; Lentin and Titley 2011; Verloo and Paternotte 2018). Widespread in Central and Eastern Europe, as well as Russia, anti-genderism presents feminism and gender theories as alien to national traditions and harmful for the younger generations, who are argued to be in need of protection from these so-called radical ideologies. Anti-gender politics receives strong support from the Catholic and Orthodox Churches, while also being promoted by conservative politicians and right-wing populists in varying national contexts (Gutiérrez Rodríguez, Tuzcu and Winkel 2018; Paternotte and Kuhar 2018).

While some scholars, as well as public intellectuals, have ‘warned’ that the ethnic and racial minority population will soon outnumber the white majority population in the United States, Carroll (2011) and Frey (2014) describe how demographic developments are influencing the United States, especially among the younger generations. A similar ‘worry over the nation’ (Hage 1998) can be observed in several European countries – though here, the discourse is often framed around Muslims and Islam, rather than whites and non-whites. The effects of these changing demographics are not only about numbers, but also about racialised interpretations and the changing power balance between differently racialised groups. Suddenly, the status and privileges related to whiteness no longer appear as self-evident. Efforts to maintain or restore the unjust power structure defined by white privilege following this

‘crisis of white hegemony’ (Keskinen 2018) have produced fierce political rhetoric and movements, such as the Alt-Right and anti-democratic mobilisations (i.e. the storming of Capitol Hill in Washington, DC on 6 January 2021 following the Presidential election of Joe Biden). Several chapters in this volume deal explicitly with the crisis of white masculinity and the crisis of white hegemony – most overtly expressed in the United Kingdom Brexit referendum and the elections of Donald Trump in the United States and Jair Bolsonaro in Brazil. Due to migration patterns to and from the post-colonial world, the very idea of the West is undergoing fundamental change, intimately linked to the idea of whiteness itself (Bonnnett 2004; Hayes 2018; Le Renard 2021). This Handbook aims at uncovering how the boundaries of whiteness are shifting across geographies, following new migration patterns, mixed identities and relations (Ali 2003).

Future directions and questions for the field

As illustrated above – and as exemplified in the chapters of this Handbook – the field of critical race and whiteness studies has now outgrown its original United States context. This outgrowth (or expansion) has included a number of attempts to re-work and re-develop the theories to suit different geographical contexts, each with their own historical specificity (Essed and Goldberg 2002). As we edited this Handbook, we were reminded of how vast the field of critical race and whiteness studies and theories has become, and how much it continues to grow. This growth is occurring in different arenas. First, there is a geographical expansion (as this Handbook shows), whereby critical race and whiteness theory is stretching into various countries in Europe, Asia, Latin America, Africa and Australia, while continuing to be relevant in its ‘birthplace’ of the United States. In all of these contexts, it is improving our understanding of contemporary societies and their tensions. Importantly, newer analyses are demonstrating skilled adaptation to the particular histories and societal conditions of their geographical field.

Second, and centrally, critical race and whiteness theories have become more nuanced, illustrating the importance of studying whiteness not only in white-dominated societies, but also in societies dominated by people of colour (e.g. Asian societies), where the frameworks can provide useful theoretical tools for understanding the complexities of power and privilege. As mentioned above, we suggest that a fourth wave of whiteness studies is emerging from this broader range of research, which highlights the specificities of different regions and national contexts. Thus, we are moving beyond the United States and European focus of previous waves, while at the same time acknowledging the shared characteristics of whiteness as a power structure within a wide variety of geographical contexts (Lan 2022; Le Renard 2021).

This Handbook aims at presenting a transnational perspective on different whitenesses, as they vary and shift across locations and continents. Although whiteness and nationalism are intimately linked in (racial) political projects, through notions of national ethnic identities, whiteness also intersects with processes of transnationalism. Furthermore, the imperial project of whiteness has undergone fundamental changes across time and place (Moreton-Robinson, Casey and Nicoll 2008). Drawing on her study of transnational representations of white femininity, Raka Shome (2011) argues that it is crucial to link the national and the transnational in the formation of whiteness. Given that ‘national contexts, today are shaped by, as well as shaping, transnational relations of power, ignoring transnational linkages in the production of whiteness is limiting, for it can potentially perpetuate a view that power relations of whiteness within the nation are somehow disconnected from larger transnational struggles and flows’ (Shome 2011, p. 404). As this Handbook shows, a transnational analysis

of racial logics deals with whiteness as lived and negotiated in relation to new and shifting social locations and boundaries, raising questions pertaining to identity, positionality, bodies, social relations and the processes of racialisation, as such.

Furthermore, the Handbook aims at continuing the transdisciplinary dialogue between critical whiteness studies, or critical studies in whiteness (cf. Hunter and Van der Westhuizen 2022), and CRT by contributing theorisation and empirical research from many parts of the world, moving beyond the previous focus on Anglo-American perspectives on race and whiteness. Theoretically, this focus acknowledges that the ‘sociological significance of “whiteness” is closely connected to the meaning of “race”’ (Doane 2003, p. 8). Indeed, rather than seeing whiteness as a separate category from race, we argue that whiteness is located in a ‘racialised social system’ and a ‘*historically contingent* social identity’, always intertwined with the history of race and racism (Doane 2003, p. 9, italics in original; see also Bonilla-Silva 1997; Garner 2007).

Over the years, CRT and critical whiteness studies have expanded into a number of disciplines, ranging from legal scholarship to the study of educational institutions, history, political science, sociology, arts and culture, philosophy and many other fields. This Handbook bears witness to this expansion, and we envision that this enlargement of critical race and whiteness studies will continue in the following years. At the same time, we do not necessarily predict that this expansion will arrive unnoticed, as there are serious attacks on this field of study, as described at the beginning of the chapter. Despite this, we do believe that there will be a development and expansion of the field, precisely because it is capable of supplying the tools, concepts and theories needed to understand and explain contemporary struggles and tensions related to race, discrimination, power and privilege.

The theoretical frameworks and analyses presented in this Handbook seek to widen the horizons of research beyond the racial hierarchies, structured inequalities and racialised hostilities that are characteristic of our times. The politics of solidarity is essential for political struggles seeking to create social change and achieve social justice (Keskinen, Skaptadóttir and Toivanen 2019b). It is also the building block of activities that bring together differently positioned subjects and social movements to provide a counterforce to white, nationalist, conservative, anti-gender, anti-feminist, anti-queer, neoliberal policies and economic structures. Such policies and frameworks are creating increasingly precarious life circumstances across the globe and effecting hostile politics towards migrants, Blacks and other people of colour in the Western world. While such politics of solidarity is often fraught with controversy, contradiction and disagreement, based on varying social positions and ideological commitments, it is nevertheless the most hopeful trend we are witnessing emerging in different parts of the world. The spread of the BLM demonstrations and the upsurge in critical knowledge that followed, as well as the broad range of anti-racist and decolonial campaigns and movements that we identified at the beginning of this chapter, are just a few examples of the possibilities embedded in a politics of solidarity that takes demands of racial justice and intersectional power relations seriously. Knowledge production and collective organising are central for this; we hope that this Handbook will contribute to opening up new avenues for these ends.

Notes

- 1 All authors have contributed equally.
- 2 The Black Lives Matter movement (#BlackLivesMatter) began in 2013 as a response to the killing of the Black teenager Trayvon Martin in 2012. With the killing of George Floyd going viral in 2020, the movement grew and spread globally, voicing criticism of racism in the United States as well as in various local and regional contexts.

- 3 Today, the historical scientists who studied race and racial hierarchies are sometimes labelled ‘pseudo-scientists’, in order to underscore that contemporary science does not agree with their research ethics, methods or results; differently, we use the term ‘scientist’ here, as these historical scholars were considered proper scientists at their time. Naming them ‘scientists’ allows us to emphasise that their science is very much part of our history.

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SECTION 1

Technologies



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2

INTRODUCTION

Technologies

Race has been analysed as a technology that creates inequalities (Benjamin 2016), sorts populations (e.g. Sheth 2009) and guides assisted reproduction (Andreassen 2018; Deomampo 2016; Russel 2018). Furthermore, digital technologies have also come under scrutiny, with scholars pointing to the ways in which they reproduce racism and sexism. Noble (2018) documents how traditional (prejudicial) understandings of race, sexuality and gender are integrated into Google programming, with the result that search data selections are rather biased. Noble compares Google searches to ‘the white, male gaze’ (p. 59) and describes Google’s performance as ‘algorithm oppression’ (Noble 2018, p. 4). In *Automating Inequality* (2017), Eubanks points to the unequal application of data surveillance technology within the population:

George Orwell got one thing wrong. Big Brother is not watching you, he’s watching us. Most people are targeted for digital scrutiny as members of social groups, not as individuals. People of color, migrants, unpopular religions groups, sexual minorities, the poor, and other oppressed and exploited populations bear a much higher burden of monitoring and tracking than advanced groups.

(2017, p. 6)

The chapters in this section are aligned with these arguments, claiming that technologies are not neutral, but carriers of ideologies and values (Drucker 2011; Kannabiran and Petersen 2010).

The section begins with France Winddance Twine’s chapter on ‘Silicon Valley’s caste system: Whiteness as a form of geek capital’. Here, Twine analyses the ways in which race privilege operates in the technology industry, focusing on the experiences of technically skilled women in Silicon Valley. Drawing upon critical race theory and employing an intersectional theoretical lens that illuminates the operation of caste, class, gender, race and ethnicity, she shows how white women from middle-class backgrounds are perceived as more desirable workers and members of the dominant group in Silicon Valley’s occupational caste system. Thus, whiteness serves as a form of ‘geek capital’ that grants white, university-educated women a structural advantage. Differently, university-educated and technically skilled Black and Latinx women who are first-generation technology workers from all class backgrounds encounter a ‘glass wall’ and struggle to convert their educational credentials and technical skills into full-time jobs. Even a degree in computer science or engineering does not protect them from being

rejected and excluded from jobs for which they qualify. Thus, their experiences demonstrate that merit is interpreted through a racialised lens and does not guarantee access to employment in the technology sector in California. Twine argues that the persistent ‘myth of meritocracy’ serves to rationalise and normalise the exclusion of Black, Latinx and Native American women in technically skilled positions. She also points to the social segregation of technology workers (by race, caste, class, national origin, religious faith and/or occupation) as an obstacle for the organisation of technology workers in pursuit of intersectional justice.

Following a similar line, in the chapter ‘Artificialising whiteness? How AI normalises whiteness in theory, policy and practice’, Pauline Leonard analyses artificial intelligence (AI) from the perspectives of critical race and whiteness theory, socio-technical studies and governmentality. She shows how contemporary operationalisations of AI, such as automated decision-making processes, can be understood as tools for securing the privileges and power of whiteness, despite being positioned under the guise of neutral technology. Investigating the intersections of these processes with gender and social class, Leonard demonstrates how they consistently and routinely artificialise whiteness by disadvantaging members of marginalised groups. As a consequence, minorities – and particularly Black and ethnic minority women – become further marginalised and potentially subjected to unfair and biased (automated) decision-making. She concludes that many of the United States AI systems – as well as the AI industry, more broadly – collude in artificialising whiteness. She therefore advocates for a recognition of AI as a racial, gendered and classist system of governance that seeks to reassert, renew and normalise facets of white supremacy.

The final chapter, ‘White time: The relationship between racial identity, contexts, interactions and temporality’, by Matthew Hughey, investigates time as a technology, and the relationship between time and race. Hughey nuances the normative understanding of time and temporal experience as constant, arguing that different social groups – and especially ethnic and racial collectives – are subject to different temporal constraints and hold varied perceptions of time. Simply put, time is racialised. While this insight could lead to a reductionist appraisal of people of colour, Hughey provides a corrective to this line of argumentation by claiming that temporal sensitivities contribute to experiences of racial belonging and identity. Analysing data from four all-white organisations, Hughey shows how particular understandings of time contribute to shaping white racial identity and white belonging, how white racial identity and various racialised settings shape perceptions of time and how such interpretations serve as mechanisms of a racialised social order.

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